PassFrame
TUITION

Strange Creatures of a Far-off Island

Year 5 — 11+ Homework Worksheet (PassFrame Tuition)

Comprehension | Non-fiction (Journal)

Extract — read it carefully before answering

12th March — Our ship anchored this morning off an island so remote that, according to the captain, no chart has ever recorded its exact position. I went ashore with two companions to begin my survey of the local wildlife, and within an hour I had filled an entire notebook with observations.

The most remarkable creature we encountered was a tortoise of truly astonishing size — larger, I should think, than any tortoise described in the scientific journals of home. Its shell, mottled brown and grey, was patterned like the bark of an ancient tree, and it regarded us with a slow, unhurried curiosity, entirely unafraid, as though it had never once encountered a human being in its long life.

Along the black volcanic shoreline, we found lizards unlike any I had studied before: strange, spiny creatures that dived without hesitation into the crashing surf to feed on seaweed, surfacing minutes later entirely unbothered by the cold water. My companion, a keen student of natural history, remarked that he had never heard of a lizard that chose the sea over the land, and I confess I shared his astonishment.

Perhaps strangest of all were the birds. They showed no fear of us whatsoever, allowing us to walk among them and even touch their feathers, as though generations of living without predators had erased all memory of danger from their small minds.

I left the island that evening with a notebook full of wonders and a growing conviction that places cut off from the rest of the world develop in ways no naturalist could easily predict.

Questions

25 min · 12 questions

1. What date is given at the start of the extract?

2. Who went ashore with the writer?

3. Underline the sentence that tells you the lizards behaved unusually for their kind.

4. Underline the sentence that shows the writer's companion was also surprised.

5. What does “astonishing” mean as it is used to describe the tortoise's size?

6. Put these events in order: the writer studies the birds / the ship anchors offshore / the writer observes the lizards / the writer fills a notebook with notes.

7. Why might isolation (being cut off from the rest of the world) explain the animals' lack of fear?

8. What colour is the tortoise's shell, and what is it compared to?

9. Why do you think the writer describes feeling a “growing conviction” by the end of the entry?

10. What does the phrase “no naturalist could easily predict” suggest about island wildlife?

11. Find and copy a word that means “remarkable” or “extraordinary”, used to describe the tortoise.

12. Write one or two sentences giving your own opinion on why studying remote islands might matter to scientists.